

The Sunnysvale Statement

on the Stewardship of Scripture

In the past centuries, innovations in technology have greatly increased the distribution of Scripture. However, this progress has been hindered in other ways: Anti-Christian authorities continue to inhibit access as they always have, yet some of the greatest threats to the dissemination of the Word of God come from within our own institutions. The seventeenth century introduced exclusive publishing rights that limited the printing of the Authorized Version of the Bible. The eighteenth century witnessed the advent of modern copyright law, a legal mechanism that, by design, restricts the free propagation of Scripture. In our own day, these regulations have only expanded, and their impact has increased with the invention of digital publishing.

God has given his Word freely; no man has the authority to control or limit its transmission (2 Tim 2:9). The Author of Scripture has protected and preserved this Word for thousands of years, and we can trust him to continue to do so apart from human contrivances. We thank God for the labors of those who have made the Bible accessible to the nations, but we lament that many translations and editions of Scripture are burdened with legal and organizational restrictions that are ultimately inimical to the Great Commission.

Therefore, we, the undersigned, unite in one conviction: Scripture is the Word of God, and he has authorized his people to use, copy, distribute, translate, and adapt it regardless of man’s consent.

May the Word of the Lord run freely and be glorified (2 Thess 3:1), filling the earth as the waters cover the sea (Isa 11:9).

— Affirmations & Denials —

1. Concerning the Authorship of Scripture

We affirm that God is the divine Author of Scripture, the Word of God written, and has given this Word to his people as a gift.

We deny that Scripture may be regarded as merely human writing or that any may claim an exclusive right over it.

2. Concerning the Identity of Scripture

We affirm that the sixty-six books of the Old and New Testaments are the inspired Word of God, and that all forms thereof—whether autograph, apograph, recension, translation, or adaptation—retain a divine quality that necessarily entails certain liberties for those to whom they are entrusted.

We deny that any human effort, creativity, or error involved in the transmission, recension, translation, or adaptation of Scripture undermines any of these liberties.

3. Concerning the Use of Scripture

We affirm that the people of God have been given Scripture to search and meditate on, and therefore all who have access to the Word are granted the liberty to make full use of it regardless of man’s consent.

We deny that misuse or any other danger undermines this liberty, or that any have a right to forcibly restrict others from lawfully using the Word of God.

4. Concerning the Reproduction of Scripture

We affirm that the people of God have a prerogative to preserve Scripture, and therefore all who have access to the Word are granted the liberty to copy it in any medium or format regardless of man’s consent.

We deny that textual corruption or any other danger undermines this liberty, or that any have a right to forcibly restrict others from lawfully copying the Word of God.

5. Concerning the Distribution of Scripture

We affirm that the people of God are called to propagate Scripture, and therefore all who have access to the Word are granted the liberty to distribute it in any medium or format regardless of man’s consent.

We deny that misattribution, economic exploitation, or any other danger undermines this liberty, or that any have a right to forcibly restrict others from lawfully distributing the Word of God.

6. Concerning the Adaptation of Scripture

We affirm that the people of God should make full use of Scripture, and therefore all who have access to the Word are granted the liberty to adapt it regardless of man’s consent.

We deny that mistranslation, mishandling, or any other danger undermines this liberty, or that any have a right to forcibly restrict others from lawfully adapting the Word of God.